

By **GAURAV MAZUMDAR**

Sitar exponent, composer. Grammy nominee

High Priests of Raga

Indian classical music is no static realm. Breathing, evolving...its passage through the last century was a testimony to its life-force. Ten luminati on whom its ancient grammar was borne aloft to new skies

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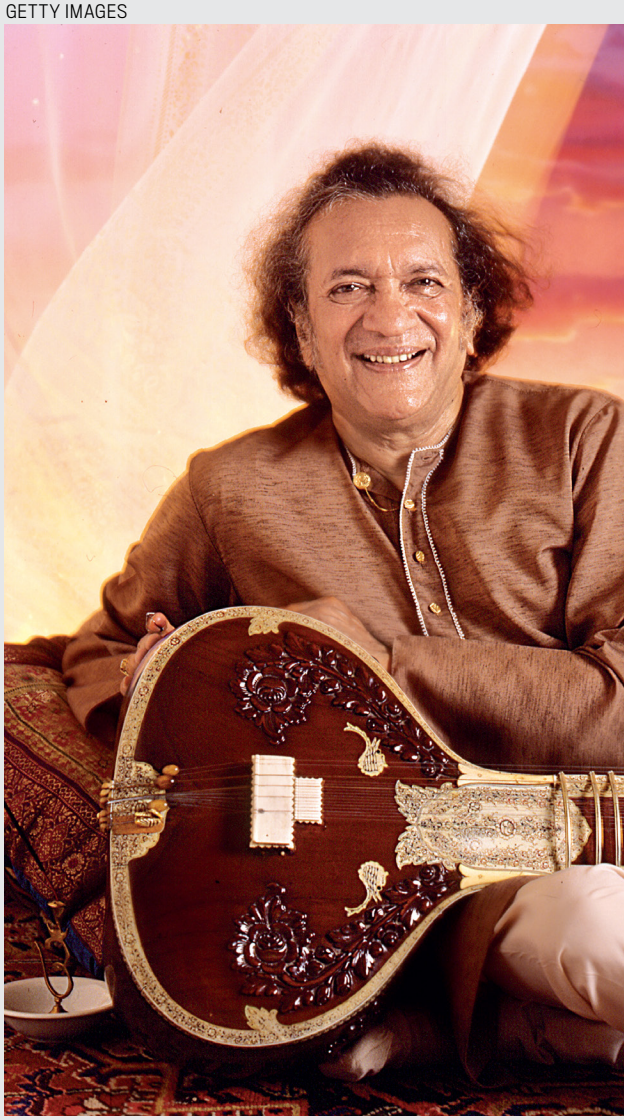


M.S. Subbulakshmi

(1916-2004)

The Hindu devotional side of south India wakes up to her *Suprabhatam* that floats out to greet every dawn. From the Devadasi tradition like dancer T. Balasaraswati, her divine voice—sweet, with hints of savoury, and amazingly nimble—gave Carnatic a national and global presence. Aside from a detour to film with *Meera* (1945), she stayed with her forte: pitch-perfect kritis and bhajans like *Annapurnashtakam*.

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Pt Ravi Shankar

(1920-2012)

Taking Indian classical music to the world as its most universally recognised envoy, parlaying that profile to popularise it within India...yet, the versatile genius stayed an enigma. He answered to a liberal ethic: witness his original collaborations, orchestral creations with both Indian and western instruments and artistes, and creation of original ragas. But he anchored it in the creative orthodoxy of his guru, Baba Allauddin Khan—never once departing from the purity of a raga. His sitar work is a canon in itself, a seed mantra for posterity.